Lesson 41

THE ANTICHRIST

(Adapted from the Foundations of Pentecostal Theology)

Aim: To teach the believers the biblical teaching of the Antichrist.

A. The Word "Antichrist" in Scripture.

The word "antichrist" comes from two Greek words christos meaning "Christ" or the "anointed one"; and anti meaning in this combination "against"; thus, "the one against Christ, God's anointed." The name "antichrist', is found only in John's epistles (1Jn 2:18, 22; 4:3; 2 Jn 7), where he is described as one coming in the last time, and one whose spirit is already present in the world. The spirit of antichrist will be embodied in the "beast" described in Revelation 13:1; 11:7. The first prophetic reference to Antichrist is probably found in Genesis 3:15: "And I will put enmity between thee and the woman and between THY SEED and HER SEED…." Christ is the SEED of woman. Antichrist is the SEED of Satan or the "Devil," whose name means "slanderer," who speaks against Christ and against His Redeemed.

1 John 2:18, 22 18Dear children, this is the last hour; and as you have heard that the antichrist is coming, even now many antichrists have come. This is how we know it is the last hour. 22 Who is the liar? It is whoever denies that Jesus is the Christ. Such a person is the antichrist—denying the Father and the Son.

1 John 4:3, 3but every spirit that does not acknowledge Jesus is not from God. This is the spirit of the antichrist, which you have heard is coming and even now is already in the world.

Revelation 13:1, 1The dragon[a] stood on the shore of the sea. And I saw a beast coming out of the sea. It had ten horns and seven heads, with ten crowns on its horns, and on each head a blasphemous name.

B. The Identity of the Antichrist

The spirit of antichrist has possessed many enemies of God through the ages, such as “the kings of Babylon,” a type of Satan (Is. 14:4-17). The name “Mystery Babylon” is borne by the “great harlot” of Revelation 17:5, for she is the embodiment of anti-God religion. Many anti-christian rulers and evil men of power have been identified as the “Antichrist” through history, such as: Nero, Napoleon, Kaisar Wilhelm,

Mussolini, Hitler, Stalin, etc. Some of these were no doubt motivated by the spirit of antichrist, but THE Antichrist is yet to come. He may be somewhere in the world already, but he will not be revealed until after the Rapture of the Church; so it is rather futile to try to identify him. The spirit of antichrist will continue to possess any vehicle yielded to Satan.

Isaiah 14:4-17, 4 you will take up this taunt against the king of Babylon: How the oppressor has come to an end! How his fury[a] has ended! 5 The LORD has broken the rod of the wicked, the scepter of the rulers, 6 which in anger struck down peoples with unceasing blows, and in fury subdued nations with relentless aggression. 7All the lands are at rest and at peace; they break into singing. 8 Even the junipers and the cedars of Lebanon gloat over you and say, "Now that you have been laid low, no one comes to cut us down." 9The realm of the dead below is all astir to meet you at your coming; it rouses the spirits of the departed to greet you— all those who were leaders in the world; it makes them rise from their thrones— all those who were kings over the nations. 10 They will all respond, they will say to you, "You also have become weak, as we are; you have become like us." 11 All your pomp has been brought down to the grave, along with the noise of your harps; maggots are spread out beneath you and worms cover you. 12 How you have fallen from heaven, morning star,

son of the dawn! You have been cast down to the earth, you who once laid low the nations! 13You said in your heart, "I will ascend to the heavens; I will raise my throne above the stars of God; I will sit enthroned on the mount of assembly, on the utmost heights of Mount Zaphon.[b]14 I will ascend above the tops of the clouds; I will make myself like the Most High." 15 But you are brought down to the realm of the dead, to the depths of the pit. 16 Those who see you stare at you, they ponder your fate: "Is this the man who shook the earth and made kingdoms tremble,7 the man who made the world a wilderness, who overthrew its cities and would not let his captives go home?"

Revelation 17:5, 5The name written on her forehead was a mystery: BABYLON THE GREAT THE MOTHER OF PROSTITUTES AND OF THE ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH.

C. The Titles of Antichrist.

1. The Beast- Rv. 13:1-4, 12-18; 15:2; 16:2; 17:8; 19:19; 20:4, 10.

Revelation 13:1-4, 12-8, The dragon[a] stood on the shore of the sea. And I saw a beast coming out of the sea. It had ten horns and seven heads, with ten crowns on its horns,

and on each head a blasphemous name. 2The beast I saw resembled a leopard, but had feet like those of a bear and a mouth like that of a lion. The dragon gave the beast his power and his throne and great authority. 3 One of the heads of the beast seemed to have had a fatal wound, but the fatal wound had been healed. The whole world was filled with wonder and followed the beast. 4 People worshiped the dragon because he had given authority to the beast, and they also worshiped the beast and asked, "Who is like the beast? Who can wage war against it?" 12 It exercised all the authority of the first beast on its behalf, and made the earth and its inhabitants worship the first beast, whose fatal wound had been healed. 13 And it performed great signs, even causing fire to come down from heaven to the earth in full view of the people. 14 Because of the signs it was given power to perform on behalf of the first beast, it deceived the inhabitants of the earth. It ordered them to set up an image in honor of the beast who was wounded by the sword and yet lived. 15 The second beast was given power to give breath to the image of the first beast, so that the image could speak and cause all who refused to worship the image to be killed. 16 It also forced all people, great and small, rich and poor, free and slave, to receive a mark on their right hands or on their foreheads, 17 so that they could not buy or sell unless they had the mark, which is

the name of the beast or the number of its name. 18 This calls for wisdom. Let the person who has insight calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man.[a] That number is 666.

Revelation 15:2, 2 And I saw what looked like a sea of glass glowing with fire and, standing beside the sea, those who had been victorious over the beast and its image and over the number of its name. They held harps given them by God 16:2, 2 The first angel went and poured out his bowl on the land, and ugly, festering sores broke out on the people who had the mark of the beast and worshiped its image.

17:8, 8 The beast, which you saw, once was, now is not, and yet will come up out of the Abyss and go to its destruction. The inhabitants of the earth whose names have not been written in the book of life from the creation of the world will be astonished when they see the beast, because it once was, now is not, and yet will come.

19:19, 19 Then I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered together to wage war against the rider on the horse and his army.

20:4, 4 I saw thrones on which were seated those who had been given authority to judge. And I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded because of their testimony about Jesus and because of the word of God. They[a] had not

worshiped the beast or its image and had not received its mark on their foreheads or their hands. They came to life and reigned with Christ a thousand years.

2. The Little Horn– Dn. 7:8; 8:9.

He shall rise up from among rulers of the revived Roman Empire. The "little horn" of Daniel 8:9 is Antiochus Epiphanes (170 B.C.), the Syrian ruler who persecuted the Jews and defiled the Temple in the time of the Maccabees (Macc.1:10-47); therefore, he is a type of Antichrist.

Daniel 7:8, 8"While I was thinking about the horns, there before me was another horn, a little one, which came up among them; and three of the first horns were uprooted before it. This horn had eyes like the eyes of a human being and a mouth that spoke boastfully.

Daniel 8:9, 9 Out of one of them came another horn, which started small but grew in power to the south and to the east and toward the Beautiful Land.

3. The Man of Sin–2Thes. 2:3.

2 Thes 2:3, 3Don't let anyone deceive you in any way, for that day will not come until the rebellion occurs and the man of lawlessness[a] is revealed, the man doomed to destruction. He will be history's vilest embodiment of sin and rebellion.

4. The Son of Perdition– 2 Thes 2:3.

Another title of the Man of Sin. Satan's tool to seduce men and consign them to the realm of the lost.

2 Thes 2:3, 3Don't let anyone deceive you in any way, for that day will not come until the rebellion occurs and the man of lawlessness[a] is revealed, the man doomed to destruction.

5. The Wicked One– 2Thes 2:8.

"Wicked" is from the Greek, anomos, which means the "lawless one." He totally opposes every law of God.

2 Thes 2:8, 8 And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will overthrow with the breath of his mouth and destroy by the splendor of his coming.

6. The Willful King– Dn. 11:36-45.

Jesus prayed, "Not my will but thine be done'; the Antichrist will oppose God's Will and do his own will; he is the inspirer of all those who "do their own thing."

Daniel 11:36-4536 "The king will do as he pleases. He will exalt and magnify himself above every god and will say unheard-of things against the God of gods. He will be successful until the time of wrath is completed, for what has been determined must take place. 37 He will show no regard for the gods of his ancestors or for the one desired by women, nor will he regard any god, but will exalt himself above them all. 38 Instead of them, he will honor a god of fortresses; a

god unknown to his ancestors he will honor with gold and silver, with precious stones and costly gifts. 39 He will attack the mightiest fortresses with the help of a foreign god and will greatly honor those who acknowledge him. He will make them rulers over many people and will distribute the land at a price.[a] 40 "At the time of the end the king of the South will engage him in battle, and the king of the North will storm out against him with chariots and cavalry and a great fleet of ships. He will invade many countries and sweep through them like a flood. 41 He will also invade the Beautiful Land. Many countries will fall, but Edom, Moab and the leaders of Ammon will be delivered from his hand. 42 He will extend his power over many countries; Egypt will not escape.43 He will gain control of the treasures of gold and silver and all the riches of Egypt, with the Libyans and Cushites[b] in submission.44 But reports from the east and the north will alarm him, and he will set out in a great rage to destroy and annihilate many. 45He will pitch his royal tents between the seas at[c] the beautiful holy mountain. Yet he will come to his end, and no one will help him.

7. The Foolish Shepherd– Zec. 11:15-17.

Jesus is the Good Shepherd who preserves; Antichrist is the worthless shepherd who devours.

Zechariah 11:15-17, 15 Then the LORD said to me, "Take again the equipment of a foolish shepherd. 16 For I am going to raise up a shepherd over the land who will not care for the lost, or seek the young, or heal the injured, or feed the healthy, but will eat the meat of the choice sheep, tearing off their hooves. 17 "Woe to the worthless shepherd, who deserts the flock! May the sword strike his arm and his right eye! May his arm be completely withered, his right eye totally blinded!"

D. The Works of Antichrist.

1. He is the last ruler of the revived Roman Empire– Dn 7:8; Rv. 13:1.

Daniel 7:8, 8"While I was thinking about the horns, there before me was another horn, a little one, which came up among them; and three of the first horns were uprooted before it. This horn had eyes like the eyes of a human being and a mouth that spoke boastfully.

Revelation 13:1, The dragon[a] stood on the shore of the sea. And I saw a beast coming out of the sea. It had ten horns and seven heads, with ten crowns on its horns, and on each head a blasphemous name.

2. He will appear on the scene as a proponent of peace who is tolerant of religion– Dn. 9:27; Rv. 6:2; Dn. 8:25; 1Thes. 5:3.

Daniel 9:27, 27 He will confirm a covenant with many for one ‘seven.’[a] In the middle of the ‘seven’[b] he will put an end to sacrifice and offering. And at the temple[c] he will set up an abomination that causes desolation, until the end that is decreed is poured out on him.[d]”[e]

Revelation 6:2, 2I looked, and there before me was a white horse! Its rider held a bow, and he was given a crown, and he rode out as a conqueror bent on conquest.

Daniel 8:25, 25 He will cause deceit to prosper, and he will consider himself superior. When they feel secure, he will destroy many and take his stand against the Prince of princes. Yet he will be destroyed, but not by human power.

1 Thessalonians 5:3, 3 While people are saying, “Peace and safety,” destruction will come on them suddenly, as labor pains on a pregnant woman, and they will not escape.

3. He will arise after the Rapture of the Church and at the beginning of the seventieth week of Daniel, when God sets His hand to deal again with national Israel, and he will make a covenant with the Jews to restore the daily sacrifice– Dn. 9:24-27.

1 Thessalonians 5:3, 24“Seventy ‘sevens’[a] are decreed for your people and your holy city to finish[b] transgression, to put an end to sin, to atone for wickedness, to bring in

everlasting righteousness, to seal up vision and prophecy and to anoint the Most Holy Place.[c] 25 "Know and understand this: From the time the word goes out to restore and rebuild Jerusalem until the Anointed One,[d] the ruler, comes, there will be seven 'sevens,' and sixty-two 'sevens.' It will be rebuilt with streets and a trench, but in times of trouble. 26After the sixty-two 'sevens,' the Anointed One will be put to death and will have nothing.[e] The people of the ruler who will come will destroy the city and the sanctuary. The end will come like a flood: War will continue until the end, and desolations have been decreed. 27 He will confirm a covenant with many for one 'seven.'[f] In the middle of the 'seven'[g] he will put an end to sacrifice and offering. And at the temple[h] he will set up an abomination that causes desolation, until the end that is decreed is poured out on him.[i][j]"

4. After three and one half years, in the middle of the Tribulation, he will cast off all pretense of toleration, break his covenant with the Jews, cause the daily sacrifice to cease, and begin his persecution of Israel– Rv. 13:7,8.

5. One of his heads will received a deadly wound, then be miraculously healed causing the wonderment and worship of the whole world– Rv. 13:3,4.

6. As the Man of Sin and Lawless One he will blaspheme God, then require the worship of all men with the threat of death– Rv. 13:7,8.

7. The third member of the satanic trinity for the Dragon, the Beast and the False Prophet arises; causes men to worship the Beast, creates an image of the Beast to which he gives life, and causes all men to take a mark or number of the Beast in order to buy or sell– Rv. 13:11-18.

8. During the Tribulation, the Beast sponsors the great Harlot who represents apostate religion, but finally the Beast together with the ten kings who rule with the Beast utterly destroy the scarlet woman– Rv. 17. The woman is said to be "that great city that reigneth over the kings of the earth" (Rv. 17-18); the city is situated on "seven mountains" (17:9). (Scholars are divided as to whether the city is Rome or Babylon.)

9. The Beast gathers his subject nations together to make war with the Lamb at the Battle of Armageddon, where he is utterly defeated and cast, together with False Prophet, into the Lake of Fire– Rv. 16:16; 17:14; 19:19, 20.

Revelation 13:11-18, Then I saw a second beast, coming out of the earth. It had two horns like a lamb, but it spoke like a dragon. 12It exercised all the authority of the first beast on its behalf, and made the earth and its inhabitants worship the

first beast, whose fatal wound had been healed. 13 And it performed great signs, even causing fire to come down from heaven to the earth in full view of the people.14 Because of the signs it was given power to perform on behalf of the first beast, it deceived the inhabitants of the earth. It ordered them to set up an image in honor of the beast who was wounded by the sword and yet lived. 15The second beast was given power to give breath to the image of the first beast, so that the image could speak and cause all who refused to worship the image to be killed.16It also forced all people, great and small, rich and poor, free and slave, to receive a mark on their right hands or on their foreheads,17 so that they could not buy or sell unless they had the Mark, which is the name of the beast or the number of its name. 18 This calls for wisdom. Let the person who has insight calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man.[a] That number is 666.

Revelation 17:99 "This calls for a mind with wisdom. The seven heads are seven hills on which the woman sits.

Revelation 17:1414 They will wage war against the Lamb, but the Lamb will triumph over them because he is Lord of lords and King of kings—and with him will be his called, chosen and faithful followers."

Revelation 16:16,16 Then they gathered the kings together to the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon.

Revelation 19:19-20,19 Then I saw the beast and the kings of the earth and their armies gathered together to wage war against the rider on the horse and his army. 20 But the beast was captured, and with it the false prophet who had performed the signs on its behalf. With these signs he had deluded those who had received the mark of the beast and worshiped its image. The two of them were thrown alive into the fiery lake of burning sulfur.